

Introduction to Literature – Course Handbook

This handbook is designed for students taking an introductory literature course. It covers the foundations of literary studies, major genres, literary devices, critical approaches, and practical writing tips for literary analysis.

What is Literature?

Literature refers to written or spoken works considered to have artistic or intellectual value. It includes novels, poems, plays, short stories, essays, and oral traditions.

Major Genres of Literature

Poetry: Expresses ideas and emotions through rhythm and imagery.

Drama: Literature written for performance on stage.

Prose: Ordinary written language including novels and short stories.

Folklore: Traditional stories, myths, and legends passed through generations.

Elements of Literature

Plot: Sequence of events in a story.

Character: Individuals in the narrative.

Theme: Central idea or message.

Setting: Time and place of the story.

Conflict: Main struggle within the story.

Literary Devices

Metaphor: Direct comparison between unlike things.

Simile: Comparison using 'like' or 'as'.

Irony: Contrast between expectation and reality.

Symbolism: Use of symbols to represent ideas.

How to Analyze a Literary Text

1. Read the text carefully.
2. Identify themes and literary devices.
3. Examine character development.
4. Analyze the author's language and style.
5. Support arguments with textual evidence.

Essay Writing Tips

- Create a clear thesis statement.
- Organize ideas into paragraphs.
- Use quotations effectively.
- Maintain formal academic language.
- Conclude by reinforcing your argument.

Quick Literary Terms Reference

Literary Term	Meaning
Theme	Main idea of a text
Protagonist	Main character
Antagonist	Opposing force or character
Alliteration	Repetition of consonant sounds
Narrator	Voice telling the story

Conclusion

Literature helps readers understand culture, history, emotions, and human experiences. Studying literature also develops critical thinking, communication skills, and creativity.